

that he would not give her party more seats than it contested in 2004. In Mumbai, an ageing Bal Thackeray could not find time to meet Advani. Around the same time, JD(U) leader and Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar visited Delhi and said Advani as prime minister was acceptable but BJP's agenda was not. He too didn't bother to meet the BJP leader. With one of India's biggest electoral war barely six weeks away, there are no signs yet of what kind of political alliances will eventually emerge. Will NDA retain its current bedfellows? Will Congress be able to get more allies on board? Last week, when members of the 14th Lok Sabha left for their constituencies after its last Parliament session, none of them was clear about the would-be friends or enemies. The stage is still wide open for deals and divorces. In this whirl, the triumvirate of Mamata, Mayawati and Jayalalithaa stands out as a sisterhood of absolute power, mightier than the so-called mightiest in Congress and BJP. And these regional divas are not in awe of any national leader.

At a time when it should be at its fighting best, NDA is a ramshackle house. Its only achievement is in projecting a prime ministerial candidate, a war-scarred veteran in his last battle. The allies have accepted Advani's candidature but not BJP's terms and conditions of partnership. Advani, busy learning from the Obama campaign, may have little time for humouring his allies. Other BJP leaders have not succeeded in striking mutually acceptable deals with savvy negotiators like Kumar, BJD President Naveen Patnaik, Thackeray or even Shiromani Akali Dal President Parkash Singh Badal. "Why should we announce our candidates now? Let our opposition do that first and we will decide how many seats to contest from where after that," says Kumar. It was in sharp contrast to earlier declaration of the BJP leadership that it would announce all the candidates by mid-February. The party had sent 50 observers to all the states to shortlist pos-

(CLOCKWISE) MAYAWATI, MAMATA BANERJEE AND J. JAYALALITHAA HOLD THEIR CARDS CLOSE TO THEIR CHESTS DESPITE BEING ACTIVELY WOODED

The Kingdom and the Power

Having carved out their own little fiefdoms in their states, regional parties have managed to reverse the roles and now have the power to dictate to the bigger national players

BSP



5
1998
(4.63)



14
1999
(4.16)



19
2004
(5.33)

Figures in brackets are vote share in per cent

SIPRA DAS



H.K. RAJASHEKAR



SUBIR HALDER

